quite possible that this insight is what led to the Israeli saying, “There are no second chances in the Middle East.” A third insight states that at every new round of the peace process the Palestinians have demanded that the starting point of the negotiations be the Israelis’ last concession in the previous round.

Global politics of recent years have been characterized by a great deal of change, which has created a general geostrategic picture of instability and unrest in many areas, particularly the Middle East. The Soviet Union, which in the 1950s and 1960s had established a status in the Middle East similar to that of the United States, was expelled from Egypt in 1972 but partially retained its status in Syria. Today, Russia is trying to regain a much more active role in the Middle East through military intervention in Syria and the establishment of Russian-controlled land, naval, and air infrastructures for an unlimited period of time. This is a strategy that President Obama chose not to oppose.

There were indications that President Obama was interested in reducing American involvement in the Middle East. If these indications were true, I think his approach was wrong. Either way, the United States cannot afford to abandon the Middle East. Even those who argue that the areas of instability in the China Seas (the Japan-China and Philippines-China conflicts), the Korean Peninsula (between North Korea and South Korea), and the India-Pakistan border are important and sensitive cannot ignore the destructive potential of the Middle East as an almost eternal boiling point and as the region in which the “clash of civilizations” between the West and radical Islam has been most prominent in recent decades. The United States, if it wants to influence and contribute to stability in the Middle East, will not be able to do so without a physical presence—and not necessarily a military one—in the area.

The perception that the main source of instability in the Middle East is the Arab-Israeli conflict, which in the past few decades has been largely confined to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, is completely misguided. However, solving this conflict could create the potential for increased stability in the region and a significant bolstering of US influence in it, diplomatically and without the involvement of military forces.

For many years, in fact since 1949, the year in which the armistice agreements with the Arab states were signed following the War of Independence, Israel has sought to reach peace agreements with its